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Research Background Inquiry Form (RBIF) Q&A

We hope this Q&A answers your questions about completing the RBIF tab. If you need more help, please message our team using the secure portal. We are always here to assist!

1. **Where can I find instructions for preparing my RBIF tab?**
   A: Each section of the RBIF tab includes instructions and tooltips with examples. For any questions not addressed there, please contact us through the *Messages* tab in your account.

2. **Are there samples I can review before filling out my RBIF tab?**
   A: Yes. There is a sample RBIF in the tab itself, and more examples in Appendix A of your Client Packet ("Research Background Inquiry Form_Sample.docx" and "Research Background Inquiry Form_Supplementary Information_Sample.docx"). Use these samples to see the level of detail we expect when discussing your unique background and accomplishments.

3. **Why do I need to prepare the RBIF tab?**
   A: You know your professional history best. Providing detailed information in the RBIF helps us tailor your case and draft the strongest petition materials. Your responses do not need to be polished. Please focus on clear, specific answers.

4. **How do I know if my RBIF tab is complete and sufficient?**
   A: After you finish your RBIF tab, send us a message. We will review your responses and request any additional information if needed before finalizing it and advising you on the next steps.

5. **Can I include ongoing or unfinished projects in the RBIF tab?**
   A: The RBIF should focus on your most influential completed work. For ongoing projects, use the designated area in the *Proposed Employment/Proposed Endeavor* tab (Section A).

6. **Can I mention past work that is not directly related to my current projects?**
   A: Yes, as long as the work is broadly relevant to your field of expertise, it is fine to include past work that is not directly related to your current projects.

7. **Should I include my most cited work?**
   A: Yes, if your most cited paper is relevant to your proposed research or has contributed to your future direction. If you are unsure, message us for guidance.

8. **Should I include abstracts in my RBIF tab?**
   A: Focus on full-length, peer-reviewed articles or conference papers. Abstracts or pre-prints can be included if they are significant, but are usually not given as much weight by the USCIS. Limit the RBIF to up to three publications. You can list your full publication record in the *Publication Record* tab.

9. **What information should I include about how others have used my work?**
   A: For each publication, describe one specific example of a notable citation where an independent researcher cited or used your work. Include full publication details and a sentence or two about how your research was used.

10. **What counts as a notable citation?**
    A: A notable citation is one that appears in a peer-reviewed publication authored by an independent researcher (i.e., not a co-author or collaborator) and demonstrates substantial reliance on your work. This may include building upon your methods, citing your results as a key foundation for the study, or making extensive use of your findings.

11. **How should I describe notable citations?**
    A: For each notable citation, please provide:

    - The title, authors, and journal of the citing article
    - How your work was used (summarized in a sentence or two)
    - Quotes from the citing article (optional)

    See the RBIF sample for reference.

12. **Why is this information about notable citations important?**
    A: The USCIS considers notable citations strong evidence of your impact. We need you to explain how your work was used, as we may not have the technical background to interpret every citation's significance.

13. **What if my work has not received notable citations?**
    A: Cite other ways your work is recognized, such as:

    - Cited in introductions/backgrounds of other papers
    - Included in tables, charts, or images
    - Compared favorably to other approaches
    - Used or quoted in other research

    If you still have no citations, describe any impact your research or work has made through funding, collaborations, patents, technology transfer, clinical trials, or industry uptake.

14. **Can I include citations not listed on Google Scholar?**
    A: Yes, but please provide evidence (e.g. title page, reference page, and highlighted passages showing the citation).

15. **Can I include citations tracked on other databases besides Google Scholar?**
    A: No. While we understand that other databases may also track your citation counts and publication record, we should only rely on Google Scholar for your case. Submitting citation records from multiple databases can confuse USCIS officers, raise questions about discrepancies, and even increase the risk of a Request for Evidence (RFE).

16. **Can I include citations from papers not in English?**
    A: Yes. If key information (e.g. title, abstract, authors) is not in English, provide a certified translation. If needed, we can provide a translation affidavit template.

17. **Should I include student awards?**
    A: Based on our experience with the USCIS, we do not believe including your student awards will add significant value to your case, as they are generally not considered substantial evidence. However, if you would still like to include them in your Petition Letter, please leave us a message during your case preparation, and we will proceed accordingly.

18. **Should I list experience judging science fairs or evaluating co-workers as peer review experience?**
    A: No. Only include peer review for scholarly journals, conferences, dissertation committees, or grant reviews.

19. **Should I include invitations to serve on an editorial board?**
    A: Only if you are currently serving or have served and can provide proof. Do not include declined or not-yet-begun positions.

20. **Should I include memberships in professional organizations?**
    A: Yes, especially if the organization is selective or requires qualifications (e.g., a degree, years of experience). Avoid listing general or open memberships. If in doubt, include the

details and we will review.

21. **Should I include media coverage from my university or employer?**
    A: University or employer media coverage is not usually significant for the USCIS. Therefore, we do not recommend including it.

22. **Should I include invitations to present my work?**
    A: Yes, if the invitation was unsolicited and based entirely on your reputation. Presentations resulting from your submission for consideration are less significant, but may still be included if you wish.

23. **Will my RBIF be submitted to USCIS?**
    A: No. The RBIF is for our internal use in drafting your case materials and organizing your case documents. It will not be submitted to USCIS.

If you have more questions, please contact us anytime via *Messages* through your client portal.